CHAPTER SEVEN

Converting: Toward a Cognitive Theory of Religious Change

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Introduction

The term conversion may be used to refer to a range of phenomena that encompasses an individual's internal experience, the growth in spiritual maturity of the individual, and outward public affiliation. While there would seem to be a distinction between the unique inward experience and the outward change of affiliation, these processes often work together and are mutually reinforcing. A more illuminating distinction is between the use of the word "conversion" to signify a discrete *event* or an ongoing *process*.

Conversion involves the personal adoption of, and investment of faith in, a particular group of religious rituals, relationships, roles, and rhetoric, which together serves as a system of cognitive meaning for the individual. It assumes the individual is converting *from* a meaning system as well as *to* a meaning system. Conversion is thus usually the process of disruption of the existing meaning system, which results in disorientation, and eventual reorientation to a new or revised meaning system. Religious teachings may contribute to disequilibrium, facilitating and guiding transformation.

In this chapter, we will review the salient research on conversion and on cognitive psychology. We will then apply the methodology of cognitive linguistics to Christian conversion language. We will use the research in cognitive linguistics and psychology that has recently shown that metaphor is an important way of thinking and exists as one of the cognitive structures. The importance of "primary metaphors," that is, metaphors based on early childhood experiences that form the experiential basis for comprehension, will be explored.

Then, we will review the biblical scholarship on the original ancient Hebrew, Greek, and Latin words used in primary Christian texts to discuss

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conversion. In many cases, the scholarship shows that contemporary translations have substituted conceptual words for words with literal meanings, which are actually primary metaphors—the very building blocks of conceptual thought. By examining the literal language used in the ancient texts for primary metaphors, we will develop an understanding of the underlying thought structure.

We will show that the literal meanings for the Christian concept of conversion refer to the primary experience of turning and walking in a type of A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor. These concepts expressed are understandable across cultures because of the universal embodied experience of physical orientation and locomotion. Interestingly, the words are used in a subversive way, emphasizing disruption of orientation, bodily reorientation, and stepping. And, rather than using the more obvious word choices for planned journeys, the ancient texts sometimes choose words that emphasize the step-by-step, moment-to-moment quality of walking.

This analysis of the language of Christian conversion is consistent with the disruption and disorientation we have identified as a necessary intermediation between two meaning systems. However, the language may also imply a type of conversion from a fixed meaning system to a new life orientation open to continual meaning system adjustment.

Conversion Literature Review

This section of the chapter provides a brief review of some key concepts and theories in the academic field of conversion studies. Approaches from the fields of anthropology and theology are included with psychological approaches when they relate to the psychological processes of conversion.

Wallace: Mazeway Reformulation—Cultural Breakdown to Breakthrough

The anthropologist Anthony F.C. Wallace (2003) has proposed the concept of "mazeway reformulation," the view that a culture responds to potential collapse by a process of reconstitution. He posited that when a culture's meaning system is threatened, the existing core myths, rituals, and symbols are broken down and reformulated to revitalize the culture. This process occurs through a key individual who has a vision or conversion experience that modifies the old way to adapt to the current situation. The individual's new vision is spread through disciples who both communicate and adapt the original new vision, thus creating a cultural revitalization.

While Wallace's focus was on the cultural process, his model assumes a psychological dimension to the renewal of culture. Cultural renewal is possible because myths, rituals, and symbols are deeply embedded in the individual psyche and are capable of change, development, and transformation. Wallace termed these cognitive patterns of cultural meaning "mazeways."

Smith: Jungian Perspective on the Creation of the Self

Based in Jungian psychology, Curtis Smith (1990) has posited a theory of conversion that emphasizes religions as systems of symbols. His archetypal theory of conversion asserts that the human psyche is structured with shared fundamental patterns. As an individual human is confronted with a universal experience, a profound need is triggered within the person's psyche. Religious symbols provide the archetypal meaning for the experience, fulfilling the psyche's need. Thus, conversion occurs because the psyche's existing symbol system does not support the psyche in the current experience, and the new religion provides the symbol system that fulfills the psyche's need.

McFague: Religious Language Initiates Conversion through Psychic Disruption

Based on the analysis of parables by John Dominic Crossan, Sallie McFague (1978) proposed that conversion is a process of orientation, disruption, and reorientation with the parables serving to initiate conversion through disorientation. Crossan had proposed that the Christian parables—the stories told by Jesus in the Bible—should be viewed not as sources of comfort, consolation, and peace, but rather as sources of discomfort, disruption, and vulnerability. He suggested the metaphor of life as existing on a raft in the open ocean—one's stability and security is limited and something greater than we can understand is just beyond. He also suggested we view the challenge of Christian parables to our imagination as comparable to being at the edge of the raft exposed to the open ocean expanse (Crossan, 1975, pp. 41–46).

McFague embraced the raft metaphor and further argued that in authentic Christian conversion, the reorientation was not characterized "by a new stable worldview, but by a radical vulnerability" to a lifelong process of reorientation, of life on the edge of the raft (McFague 1978, pp. 258–259). Thus, she proposed that through the parables, the Christian conversion "must be a lifelong journey to pass over to a new orientation to reality" in which every day is lived in "a strange world, a new world in which to live and love" (p. 268).

Metzner: Universal Metaphors Used to Describe Transformation

The psychologist Ralph Metzner observed recurring metaphors used to describe spiritual transformation across cultures and religions. He identified ten universal metaphors: metamorphosis, awakening, uncovering, being liberated, purification by fire, wholeness from fragmentation, outbound journeys, return journeys, rebirth, and unfolding. Metzner proposed that the examination of the use of these metaphors might be helpful in stimulating spiritual transformation.

Metzner treated outbound journeys and return journeys as separate but related metaphors. However, he recognized that in actual use by spiritual

authorities, the description often included both outbound and return metaphoric components (1986, p. 106), and that the return journey metaphor presupposed an outward component (p. 132). He identified wandering and labyrinths as cases of the outward journey metaphor.

Morrison: Medieval Christian Conversion as Life Process

A historian of hermeneutics in Western culture, Karl Morrison came to see the understanding of conversion as a central theme. In his research on the meaning of conversion in the medieval period, he found that Christian conversion was understood quite differently than it is commonly understood today. Then it was understood to be a lifelong inward process of the heart turning toward Christ and subsequent reformation.

Morrison notes that the notion of a slow process of conversion rather than a sudden change is present in the Christian New Testament in both the metaphors used and in the example of the convert Paul. The metaphors of "germination, growth and fecundity are not metaphors of sudden change" (1992, p. 38). Similarly, although Paul is often cited as the exemplar of sudden conversion,

> Paul realized the consequences of his vocation slowly, not only in the days immediately following it, but also in the fourteen years that he spent in Arabia before he undertook his apostolate and in the tentative beginnings that eventually directed him to the Gentiles. (p. 38)

Rambo: Conversion as a Multi-Stage Process

Rambo has reviewed contemporary studies of conversion in the social science literature encompassing psychology, sociology, and anthropology. He presents conversion as a dynamic interaction that takes place in a set of interlocking systems. Rambo proposes a seven-stage conversion process, which incorporates both the convert's internal psychology and the external environment. He notes that conversion is accomplished by the individual's needs and aspirations, but also by the group into which the person is converted and the greater social matrix. Rambo's seven stages are: context, crisis, quest, encounter, interaction, commitment, and consequences.

Rambo distinguishes between conversion to a group and commitment to a path of transformation:

> In fact, I would argue that people who convert and remain the same are not really on a spiritual path of transformation. They have enshrined the conversion as a sacred moment and relive the event over and over again, but it has little power to transform their lives. Change is persistent and important and continuous, and most religious traditions expect and foster change by providing ideology and techniques for the ongoing development and maturation of their members. (1993, p. 163)

Cognitive Science Literature Review

This section of the chapter provides a brief review of some key concepts and theories in the academic field of mind–brain science, which may be applicable to the study of conversion.

Ramachandran and Persinger: Temporal Lobes and God Consciousness

V.S. Ramachandran and Michael Persinger have discussed the neurophysiological basis for religious experience. They have independently concluded that the temporal lobes of the brain are the site of religious experience. Ramachandran says that epileptic seizures in the temporal lobes are often accompanied by religious experiences. He posits the possibility that repeated experiences may permanently alter the pathways of the brain:

> These seizures—and visitations—last only a few seconds each time. But these brief temporal lobe storms can sometimes permanently alter the patient's personality so that even between seizures he is different from other people. No one knows why this happens, but it's as though the repeated electrical bursts inside the patient's brain (the frequent passage of massive volleys of nerve impulses within the limbic system) permanently "facilitate" certain pathways or may even open new channels, much as water from a storm might pour downhill, opening new rivulets, furrows, and passages along a hillside. This process, called kindling, might permanently alter—and sometimes enrich—the patient's inner emotional life (Ramachandran and Blakeslee 1998, p. 179).

Persinger (1983,1993) has carried out a program of research to document and explore the relationship between stimulation of the temporal lobe structures and types of religious experience.

Freeman: Brain Structure, Chaos, and the Scrooge Effect

The neurobiologist Walter Freeman has researched the brain structure of learning and the acquisition of new material that is inconsistent with previously learned material. Freeman has concluded that a mechanism for unlearning, dissolution of existing structure, is necessary before new material can be incorporated into the structure. Chaos must be induced in order for the brain to replace the existing structure with a new structure that incorporates the anomalous information. The process of learning new anomalous material is thus one of order, chaos, and then new order.

Freeman has related this learning process to normal socialization processes, as well as to the techniques for behavior modification in religious conversions. He labeled it the "Scrooge Effect": "The dissolution prepares for new learning by self-organization, where-by the pre-existing life history of an individual is transiently weakened, even melted down, so that new structure can grow that is not logically consistent with all that came before" (2003, p. S59).

Freeman identifies biological techniques for inducing dissolution including isolation, severe physical exercise, fasting, lack of sleep, and the induction of powerful emotional states.

Varela, Thompson, and Rosch: Buddhism and Cognitive Science

Francisco Varela, Evan Thompson, and Eleanor Rosch have presented the understandings of the cognitive structure of the brain developed by cognitive science in juxtaposition with descriptions of Buddhist mindfulness/awareness practice (Varela). Both approaches result in the ultimate conclusion of a lack of ultimate foundations for either the individual's mind or its objects, the world. Their conclusion is reminiscent of McFague's conclusion regarding the parables in its letting go of a clinging to absolute ground:

> When we widen our horizon to include transformative approaches to experience, especially those concerned not with escape from the world or the discovery of some hidden, true self but with releasing the everyday world from the clutches of the grasping mind and its desire for absolute ground, we gain a sense of perspective on the world that might be brought forth by learning to embody groundlessness as compassion in a scientific culture. (1993, p. 254)

Lakoff and Sweetser: Cognitive Linguistics

Historically, metaphor has been seen as a trope or embellishment to language. However, late-twentieth-century work in linguistics and cognitive science has shown that, rather than an embellishment, metaphor is an important way that people think. The "mind contains an enormous system of general conceptual metaphors—ways of understanding relatively abstract concepts in terms of those that are more concrete" (Lakoff 2001, p. 265).

We draw from our experiences of sensorimotor physical movement to reason conceptually about abstract things. Primary metaphors are experientially grounded mappings from the sensorimotor domain to the domain of subjective judgment. George Lakoff and Mark Johnson explain:

> Primary metaphors are part of the cognitive unconscious. We acquire them automatically and unconsciously via the normal process of neural learning and may be unaware that we have them. We have no choice in this process. When the embodied experiences in the world are universal, then the corresponding primary metaphors are universally acquired. This explains the widespread occurrence around the world of a great many primary metaphors. (1999, p. 56)

Thus, primary metaphors are actually part of the mind—neural connections between sensorimotor experience and subjective experience.

Research regarding the primary metaphor KNOWING IS SEEING demonstrates both early childhood, acquisition and general cross-cultural directionality from sensorimotor experience to conceptual experience. Chris Johnson (1999) has shown the original conflation of knowing and seeing in the language use of the child "Shem." In early childhood, the use of a phrase like "I see what you mean," would refer to a physical case of visually perceiving and thus comprehending the caretaker's meaning regarding a physical object. Later, a phrase like "I see what you mean" would also be used as a metaphorical expression of comprehension with no actual visual component.

Eve Sweetser's etymological research (1990) has shown the general historical linguistic trend that words for seeing tend to later acquire the meaning of knowing as well.

In metaphor theory, the word "domain" is used to describe a category of experience. The "source" domain is the more concrete or familiar area of experience. The "target" domain is the less familiar or abstract concept, the goal or target of understanding. The mind "maps" from the familiar source domain onto the target domain. Mappings are tightly structured and these correspondences are a fixed part of our conceptual systems.

Some other examples of primary metaphors cited by Lakoff and Johnson (1999) include:

- STATES ARE LOCATIONS;
- CHANGE IS MOTION;
- ACTIONS ARE SELF-PROPELLED MOTIONS;
- PURPOSES ARE DESTINATIONS.

In the notation of metaphor theory, the abstract concept, the target domain, is listed on the left, and the source domain, the concrete sensorimotor experience, is listed on the right. Thus, in the examples above, the mind maps from its primary sensorimotor experience:

- of locations to understand abstract states,
- of motion to understand change,
- of self-propelled motion to understand action, and
- of destinations to understand purposes.

We build up complex metaphors from our primary metaphors. Lakoff and Johnson use the metaphor A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY to illustrate the idea of complex metaphors (Lakoff and Johnson 1999, pp. 60–63). Spatial location and physical movement are inherent in this classic example. This complex metaphor A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY includes two of the primary metaphors listed earlier: PURPOSES ARE DESTINATIONS and ACTIONS ARE MOTIONS. The complex metaphor also includes the fact that a long trip to a series of destinations is a journey.

Unlike primary metaphors, complex metaphors may be culture specific. Lakoff and Johnson propose the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY

metaphor as an example that is pervasive in contemporary Western culture but is not universal. Lakoff explains that, along with primary metaphors and facts, this metaphor requires the cultural belief that people are supposed to have life purposes.

They propose that the experience of a journey with a traveler, destinations, and an itinerary is mapped onto the concept of a purposeful life as follows:

- A PERSON LIVING A LIFE IS A TRAVELER;
- LIFE GOALS ARE DESTINATIONS;
- A LIFE PLAN IS AN ITINERARY;

Here LIFE GOALS ARE DESTINATIONS is a special case of the primary metaphor referred to earlier, PURPOSES ARE DESTINATIONS. This metaphor carries with it our cultural expectations about journeys and maps them onto life purpose.

> A journey requires planning a route to your destinations. Journeys may have obstacles, and you should try to anticipate them. You should provide yourself with what you need for your journey. As a prudent traveler, you should have an itinerary indicating where you are supposed to be at what times and where to go next. You should always know where you are and where you are going next. (Lakoff and Johnson 1999, p. 62)

When these cultural judgments about journeys are mapped onto the concept of PURPOSEFUL LIFE, a series of powerful inferences, judgmental "shoulds," are created:

- If a journey requires planning, then one's life requires planning.
- If one should anticipate obstacles on a journey, then one should anticipate obstacles in life.
- If one should bring provisions on a journey, then one should provide for oneself in life.
- If a journey requires an itinerary, then life requires a planned set of goals.

These are not logical conclusions from primary sensorimotor experience, but mappings from a culturally based complex metaphor.

The Language of Christian Conversion

Metaphor is the way people think at the deepest level. The methodology of metaphor theory has recently been applied to religious concepts. Edward Slingerland (2004) has used metaphor theory as a methodology for comparative religion to understand Chinese Confucian moral concepts. Mary

Therese DesCamp and Eve Sweetser (2005) have used metaphor theory to explore the cognitive understanding of God in Christian and Hebrew texts.

The methodology of metaphor theory may also be used to explore the Christian concept of conversion. One of our primary experiences is our physical embodied location in space. This experience is applied through metaphor to help us understand many important concepts including time, love relationships, and life purposes. The Christian language of conversion is an expression of a spatial location metaphor. The words used for concepts of Christian religious conversion and new lifestyle are really expressions of primary sensorimotor experience. They literally express the experiences of turning and walking along a path.

The original literal meanings of the ancient Hebrew, Greek, and Latin words used to discuss conversion are actually about spatial reorientation. All three ancient words carry some connotation or possibility that the turning is a returning toward an earlier or original position.

Conversion is the English word used to translate the concept from the Hebrew Bible expressed in Hebrew as *sub*. This Hebrew word literally means "to turn." "The verb sub, translates the idea of changing route; to come again, to retrace one's steps. In a religious context, it means to be turned away from what is bad and to be turned toward God" (Leon-Defour 1967, p. 486). An example that clearly illustrates this usage is from Jeremiah: "It may be when the house of Judah hears of all the disasters that I intend to do to them, all of them may *turn* from their evil ways and, so that I may forgive their iniquity and their sin" (Jer. 36:3, NRSV, p. OT 488). Isaiah uses the journey in the Exodus from Egypt and the return to the Promised Land as a redeemed people as the metaphor for group conversion: "I have swept away your transgressions like a cloud, and your sins like mist; *return* to me, for I have redeemed you" (Isa. 44:22, NRSV, p. OT 927). In the Greek version of the Hebrew Bible, the Septuagint, *sub* is translated as *epistrephein*, which also means literally to turn.

The Christian religion incorporates the Hebrew Bible as its "Old Testament" and calls the new Christian religious material the "New Testament." The New Testament, originally in Greek, continued to use *epistrephein*. When the New Testament was translated into Latin, the word used was *conversio*, again rooted in the concept of directional rotation. In this following example from Acts, the turning from is both literal and metaphorical because Paul's speech occurs outside the temple of Zeus where the people wish to sacrifice after Paul healed a man with crippled feet: "Friends, why are you doing this? We are mortals just like you, and we bring you good news, that you should *turn* from these worthless things to the living God, who made the heaven and the earth and the sea and all that is in them" (Acts 14:15, NRSV, p. NT 182). In the following example from the Epistles of Peter, the metaphor of a shepherd and sheep is used to describe Christian conversion: "For you were going astray like sheep, but now you have *returned* to the shepherd and guardian of your souls" (1 Pet. 2:25, NRSV, p. NT 340).

Corollary to the spatial location literal meaning of conversion, the words to discuss Christian lifestyle are about self-locomotion. The literal meaning of life conduct is walking along a path or way.

> References to walking in the ways of God or his law would make up a small anthology of biblical verses (there are over a hundred references in Psalms and the book of Proverbs alone). Specimen passages include the following: "He leads me in right paths" (Ps. 23:3, NRSV); "I will instruct you and teach you the way you should go" (Ps. 32:8, NRSV); "to those who go the right way I will show the salvation of God" (Ps. 50:23, NRSV); "you search out my path . . . and are acquainted with all my ways" (Ps. 139:3, NRSV). (Ryken 1998, p. 630)

It is noteworthy that one of the Psalms referenced above is the familiar Psalm 23, which begins "The Lord is my shepherd, I shall not want" (Ps. 23:1, NRSV, p. OT 691). Thus, the quotation from 1st Peter above, which refers to the sheep returning to the shepherd, is a cultural reference that connects "return" to known imagery of "right paths."

In the New Testament, both the Gospel of John and the Epistles make frequent use of the "walk" and "way" to refer to the Christian life (Banks 1987).

Marilyn Harran's summary of St. Augustine's conversion language is also instructive:

> Man may be either turned to God by humble piety or turned away from Him by lifting up the horn of false liberty. Once man is converted to God, he does not simply occupy a stable, unchanging position, but begins to travel the arduous road of pilgrimage. Conversio transforms peregrinato from an undirected movement of aimless wandering into a directed movement of hopeful pilgrimage toward rest in God. (1983, p. 26)

The Christian A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY *Metaphor*

The Christian language of conversion is based on a spatial metaphor of directional rotation. Can we break down this language into metaphoric structure? It would seem to be a specific case of the **A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY** metaphor, that is, **A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS WALKING.**

> As always, symbolic meanings grow out of the physical phenomenon. Walking on a path involves choosing to enter on the path and to pursue it in a given direction, progress toward a destination, making wise rather than foolish choices along the way, taking care for safety and not getting lost, and arriving at a goal. (Ryken 1998, p. 630)

The questions then become the where, how, and with whom of the metaphor submappings. It is important to note that the **A PURPOSEFUL**

LIFE IS WALKING metaphor is not always used in a consistent manner. While it is always true that the more abstract concept of one's life is mapped onto the concrete experience of walking, the submappings may differ:

LIFE CHOICES ARE DIRECTIONAL CHOICES
LIFE CHOICES ARE PATHS (OR WAYS)
STYLE OF LIFE IS STYLE OF WALKING
GOD IS THE COMPANION
GOD IS THE LEADER
GOD IS THE GOAL

It is also noteworthy that Jesus' instructions to his apostles sometimes directly contradict the cultural expectations about journeys from the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor:

> Take no gold, or silver, or copper in your belts, no bag for your journey, or two tunics, or sandals, or a staff; for laborers deserve their food. (Matt. 10:9–10, NRSV)
>
> When they hand you over, do not worry about how you are to speak or what your are to say: for what your are to say will be given to you at that time; for it is not you who speak, but the Spirit of your Father speaking through you. (Matt 10:19–20, NRSV)
>
> He said to his disciples, "Therefore I tell you, do not worry about your life, what you will eat, or about your body, what you will wear. For life is more than food, and the body more than clothing. Consider the ravens, they neither sow nor reap, and yet God feeds them. Of how much more value are you than the birds! And can any of you by worrying add a single hour to the span of your life? If then you are not able to do so small a thing as that, why do you worry about the rest? (Luke 12: 22–27, NSRV)

Applying these precepts, the cultural inferences from the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor are reversed:

- A journey requires planning becomes do not plan;
- One should anticipate obstacles on a journey becomes do not anticipate;
- One should bring provisions on a journey becomes do not bring provisions;
- A journey requires an itinerary becomes do not use an itinerary.

A Straight and Narrow Path or a Labyrinth?

The language of Christian conversion may be advising temporary disorientation in order to reorient the individual to a new meaning system.

Alternatively, the language may be suggesting a permanent disorientation, that is, a continual state of openness to change. This may be expressed in the comparison of walking a straight and narrow path and walking a twisting, turning maze or labyrinth.

Conversion as reorientation to walking a straight and narrow path would be comparable to Lakoff's description of the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor with his cultural inferences. One knows the rules. One knows where one is going. One can assess one's progress and the progress of others. These concepts are frequently expressed by converts to Christianity. This kind of conversion is a subtype of the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor, which may be called A CHRISTIAN LIFE IS WALKING A STRAIGHT AND NARROW PATH. This is a subtype of the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor where a CHRISTIAN LIFE is a subtype of a PURPOSEFUL LIFE and WALKING A STRAIGHT AND NARROW PATH is a subtype of a JOURNEY.

However, we have found in primary Christian texts another subtype of the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor, which may be called the A CHRISTIAN LIFE IS WALKING A LABYRINTH metaphor. When walking a labyrinth, one is on a path, however, one is required to continually turn and continue along a new orientation. Here, once again, a CHRISTIAN LIFE is a subtype of a PURPOSEFUL LIFE. The subtype of JOURNEY is WALKING A LABYRINTH.

The use of the labyrinth for this metaphor is chosen based on the language we have analyzed. However, it is also consistent with medieval Christian symbolism. In her historical study of labyrinths, Penelope Doob presents the important distinction between multicursal and unicursal labyrinths. In multicursal labyrinths, there are "wrong" choices; not all paths lead to the goal. In unicursal labyrinths, there may be many twists and turns, but there is only one path; so to continue is to eventually reach the goal. The image of the unicursal labyrinth was an important symbol in medieval Christianity. They were frequently carved into placed baptismal fonts and inlaid in the floors of cathedrals (1990, pp. 117–133). Doob's analysis concludes that the church was teaching that, with Christ, the confusing and unstable turnings of life, the baffling complexities, are actually superbly articulated designs by God. We can add that the unicursal center represented God and eternal life as the goal.

The labyrinth metaphor represents the twisting, turning journey of lifelong Christian conversion. This type of imagery is present not only in the medieval universal labyrinth motif, but also in the language of Christian mystics. For example, in his discussion of journey metaphors, Metzner referred to the sixteenth-century Christian saint Theresa of Avila's description of what seems to be a labyrinth-type journey through the inner castle:

> In it, the human soul is likened to a crystalline castle surrounded by seven concentric "mansions." The innermost circle is that of the King of Glory, the indwelling Spirit who is the Sun, the Light that is the center of Being. Each mansion has many rooms, many doors, passages,

> gardens, mazes, fountains: these are the many aspects and facets of our nature, which, according to Teresa, the soul must be permitted to explore. (1986, p. 122)

It is interesting also to note that Wallace chose mazeway as metaphoric language to describe how the processes of the mind itself are formulated and reformulated.

The **A CHRISTIAN LIFE IS WALKING A LABYRINTH** metaphor may recur in the Christian tradition because its submappings and inferences closely fit the experience it is meant to express. The word inferences is used to discuss the results that occur in both the metaphor and the more conceptual experience the metaphor is used to understand. Some important inferences for the medieval unicursal labyrinth are:

1. In the physical experience of a labyrinth, one cannot assess one's progress toward one's goal. In walking the path of the labyrinth, one may be closer to the center at one point, and then out at the edge soon after. Being close to the center does not necessarily indicate one is near the end of the journey. The journey twists in and out before the end is reached. This has a disturbing corollary for Christian spiritual growth. One may need to face away and walk away from God as perceived in order to continue on the path and eventually reach God.
2. As one walks the labyrinth, one cannot assess one's progress in relation to others. The other who now appears at the outer edge may be closer to the end of the journey to the center than one is. Similarly, Christian teaching emphasizes the inability to judge the other.
3. As one walks the labyrinth, one must be willing to turn in the opposite direction, again and again. It is correct to walk north, then it is correct to walk south. It is only not correct to refuse to turn or to make one's own path. The corollary in Christian spiritual growth may be that one must be open to about-faces in religious matters. What was the obvious and appropriate course of action may no longer be so. One may have been following the direction of the Holy Spirit and may continue to do so, even (or especially) as one reverses course. In the labyrinth, each reverse in course is actually leading us closer to the center.

The raft metaphor of Crossan and McFague would be very similar to the medieval unicursal labyrinth if it were a type of river rafting trip rather than a raft on the open ocean. We can imagine a first-time river rafting trip on a twisting route to the sea. This would preserve the quality of life on the edge of the raft, but place it within an unknown but structured experience with a definite conclusion. Many of the inferences for the medieval unicursal labyrinth would transfer to such a raft trip experience.

The **A CHRISTIAN LIFE IS WALKING A LABYRINTH** metaphor may be understood to be about converting rather than about conversion.

In conversion, one has reoriented to a fixed meaning system. In the A CHRISTIAN LIFE IS WALKING A LABYRINTH metaphor, one is in a continual process of reorientation, continually converting.

Conclusions

Conversion may be defined as an initial God consciousness experience, as a commitment to a particular set of meaning-making beliefs, or as an ongoing life experience. We have examined the language in primary Christian texts to study the metaphors used in discussing conversion. Lakoff and Sweetser have shown that metaphors are the way humans make meaning. By examining metaphors, we can understand the basic conceptual structures used to reason. Thus, our examination of the metaphors used to discuss conversion illuminates the conceptual structures used to reason about this spiritual experience.

We have found that the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor is used repeatedly in discussing conversion. However, in the Christian texts, this metaphor has two distinct subcases with very different inferences for the understanding of the conversion experience.

In the A CHRISTIAN LIFE IS WALKING A STRAIGHT AND NARROW PATH metaphor, conversion is the temporary experience of being placed on the path. The conversion experience, with its disruption of one's meaning system, is a temporary experience necessary for of the reorientation to a new or revised meaning system. Conversion is the precursor to a permanent meaning system, which can be described metaphorically as a STRAIGHT AND NARROW PATH. The inferences from this metaphoric model are confidence, certainty, and a refusal to deviate.

The second Christian subtype of the A PURPOSEFUL LIFE IS A JOURNEY metaphor, which we found in our examination of the embodied metaphor in the actual words used in Christian texts to describe conversion, is A CHRISTIAN LIFE IS WALKING A LABYRINTH. In this metaphor system, conversion is an ongoing process of continual reorientation. Conversion as an ongoing process is similarly described through McFague's examination of the Christian parables, and Varela, Thompson, and Rosch's examination of Buddhist mindfulness. The inferences from this metaphoric model are humility and an openness to change.

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